



Intent Engineering Workflow

A practical workflow from the book.

Agents generate code. Teams still need durable intent.

1

Structure

Make the repo legible in plain text.

File structure, architecture, design docs, and ADRs come first.

2

Instructions

Point agents at rules they can load and follow.

Use AGENTS.md, instruction hubs, skills, and hooks by job.

3

Specs

Define one small change at a time.

Capture acceptance criteria, constraints, and boundaries.

4

Implementation

Keep generated code downstream of intent.

The agent builds from the spec, not from guesswork.

5

Proof

Map tests and checks back to acceptance criteria.

Evidence beats ritual.

6

Review

Review intent first, proof second, diff third.

Start upstream, where the real mistake usually starts.

Artifacts

docs/ and indexes explain the system.

AGENTS.md points at the right instructions.

Small specs hold one change at a time.

ADRs capture cross-cutting decisions.

Tests tie back to stable acceptance criteria.

Failure Modes

Context lives in somebody's head.

The spec is too large for one pass.

Instructions sound wise but cannot be checked.

Tests exist but do not prove intent.

Review starts at the diff.